Preschoolers track and socially evaluate social includers and excluders

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Introduction

Social exclusion is harmful and leads to impairments in the cognitive and social domains. To alleviate the effects of social exclusion, young children employ strategies to establish social reconnection, including attending to social conventions and the mental states of others (Watson-Jones et al., 2015; White et al.,2016). An even more direct way to limit the harm of exclusion would be to keep track of those who have excluded children previously and to base future social decisions on this interpersonal history.

We thus investigated whether preschoolers recall who excluded them; how they evaluate includers and excluders; and whether children's play experiences support selectivity in subsequent interpersonal behavior.

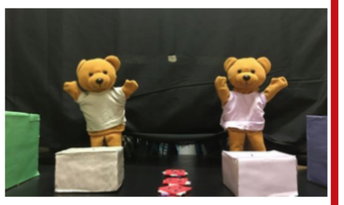
Intro Phase

Mice pair 1

Mice pair 2

Practice Phase

Learn to play catch



Learn to give items

Games Phase

Inclusion

Exclusion

Test Phase

Study 1 - Mice present

Study 2 - Mice absent

Conclusions

Surprisingly, preschoolers do not always answer the memory check correctly. Those who did successfully pass the memory check presented the following behaviors:

- Niceness is rated based on the inclusion or exclusion the child experienced
- Both 4- and 5-year-olds rated the includer as a better sharer
- Preschoolers, when prompted, share their evaluations through the recommendation of the includer to a newly introduced character.

Methods

Introductions

Children met two different pairs of mice puppets.

Practice Phase

Children learned to play catch on the stage and how to give items to a separate pair of puppets.

Games

(order counterbalanced)

Children played catch with each mouse pair. Each time, children received two throws and then…

Inclusion: …the mice threw to both the child and each other for 30 more throws.

Exclusion: …the mice threw to only each other for 30 more throws.

Test Measures

	Study 1	Study 2
Social evaluation		
"Who is meaner?"	✓	✓
"Who is nicer?"		✓
"Who is a better sharer?"	✓	✓
"Who has more friends?"	✓	
Resource allocation		
Distribute 3 stickers	✓	✓
3rd-party suggestion		
"Who should Horsey play with?"	✓	✓
Memory check (always last)		
"Who played with you more?"		✓

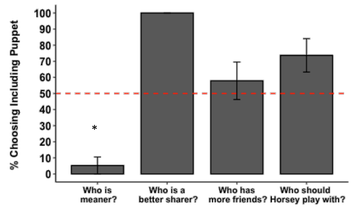
Study 1

Participants
32 4-year-olds (19 f)

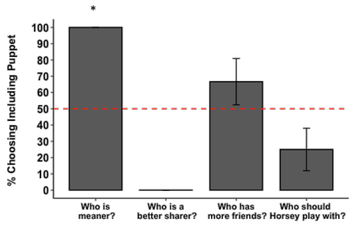
No significant results overall!

→ But did children even remember what happened?

19 chose the Includer as better sharer
…and answered consistently:



12 chose the Excluder as better sharer
…and also answered consistently
(but contrary to our predictions)



Study 2a

Participants
32 4-year-olds (16 f)

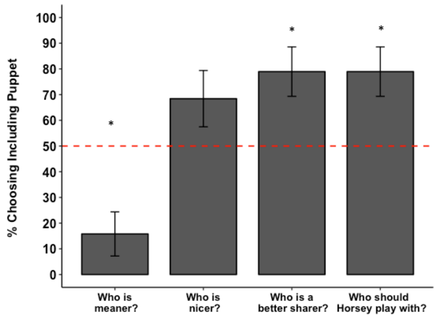
Study 2b

Participants
32 5-year-olds (17 f)

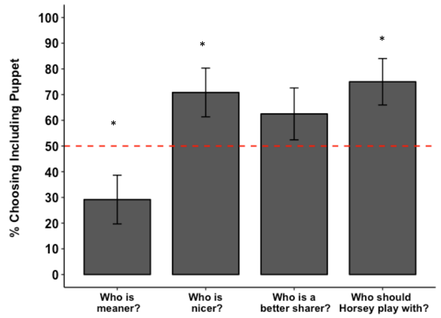
Again, no significant results overall.

But, ***conditioned on the planned memory check***, clear responses:

Memory Check correct
(n = 20 of 32)



Memory Check correct
(n = 24 of 32)



Future Directions

Why did only 58% of 4-year-olds and 69% of 5-year-olds accurately identify which mouse had played with them more?

Order of games did not affect their memory.

Perhaps some children did not find exclusion threatening. Despite their forced non-participation during one game of catch, the testing session was friendly overall.

We are now coding children's emotional expressions and behaviors during each game. Did children who passed the memory check also have more negative experiences of exclusion (or positive experiences of inclusion)?

Children who failed the memory check showed the opposite pattern of what we anticipated. Why does this occur? It is possible that these children did not track the identities of the excluders. Future work could investigate children's abilities to track multiple social agents.